

FUNCTIONAL HARMONY

The Harmony OS Color System — three categories that explain where every chord comes from and what it does emotionally.

THE HARMONY OS COLOR SYSTEM

GREEN

DIATONIC

Chords naturally in the key. Home base. Provide stability, coherence, and the foundation of all harmony. These are the 7 chords you get "for free" from the major scale.

BLUE

SECONDARY DOMINANT

Non-diatonic dominant chords. Each contains a tritone. Create directed motion toward a specific diatonic target chord. "V7 of [target]" — borrowed from tonicized keys.

RED

MODAL INTERCHANGE

Borrowed chords from parallel modes (same root, different scale). Create emotional contrast without leaving the key center. The "darkness dial" — adds depth, drama, surprise.

DIATONIC CHORD CHART — KEY OF C MAJOR

DEGREE	TRIAD	7TH CHORD	FUNCTION	STABILITY	COLOR
I Tonic	C	Cmaj7	TONIC	Home, arrival	Green
ii Supertonic	Dm	Dm7	SUBDOMINANT	Departure, motion	Green
iii Mediant	Em	Em7	TONIC	Tonic alternate	Green
IV Subdominant	F	Fmaj7	SUBDOMINANT	Departure, color	Green
V Dominant	G	G7	DOMINANT	Tension — Home	Green
vi Submediant	Am	Am7	TONIC	Relative minor tonic	Green
vii° Leading Tone	B°	Bø7	SUB/DOM	Tension, less common	Green

The universal pattern: Major — minor — minor — Major — Major — minor — diminished. This exact quality sequence (maj-min-min-maj-maj-min-dim) is identical in ALL 12 major keys. Learn it in C major, transpose the pattern to any key.